

12 June 2003

Dear Jen,

Yesterday was another hot, slow, tedious day. It seems that I am bored all of the time now. I completed the USR and submitted it to Brigade this morning. As a Battalion, we are no longer fully capable of sustaining our mission. With only 5 of 30 tanks fully operational, we have had to find new ways of accomplishing our tasks. A lack of repair parts, and constant operations have really taken their toll on our equipment as well as our people.

Colonel Ingram reviewed my comments on the report and made some interesting changes. He expressed his concerns about an increase in emotional and combat stress related disorders in soldiers across the entire unit. We have been going since March 7 without a break. I didn't know this, but we are the only unit in the Army that has not had a break since we came over here. No wonder we are all tired and burned out. The Colonel even told us yesterday that he is suffering from fatigue. He has noticed himself getting upset about little things, and often has to catch himself and say, "Why am I mad about that?"

Also, yesterday, a private in our mortar platoon showed the typical symptoms of stress. I don't know the exact circumstances, but he became upset by something and threw his weapon, threatening to kill himself. The Sergeant Majors, as you can imagine, were pissed off. It became a huge spectacle, and the soldier was sent to the medical unit for psychiatric evaluation. The Chaplain tried to intervene but was told that this was not his business. This is not the first time something like this has happened. Two other soldiers have pulled their weapons on co-workers or supervisors since we have been here.

The first was 2LT Corbett, who pointed his loaded 9mm at 1LT Williams, our physician's assistant. Corbett was the medical platoon leader, but he never worked well with either Major Grado, our doctor, or the PA. True, he was somewhat incompetent and always seemed to miss the point, but he didn't seem to get much support. He was constantly harangued by Major Wick and the Doc. One day, the story goes, the PA and Corbett got in an argument about the awards different members of the platoon were eligible for. The PA threatened to throw all of Corbett's things out of their room. I guess Corbett, who is not a big guy, was intimidated and pulled a gun on the PA. Either way, he is no longer a platoon leader. He now spends his days at the FTCP with no real duty at all.

I don't know very much about the second incident either. I know that it involves a private at the FTCP who was in an argument with his Sergeant. Apparently, this particular private was somewhat volatile to begin with and the stress of being here surely has not helped him. Again, I don't know how it all came to happen, but this private pointed his loaded M-16 at his sergeant and threatened to kill him. The first time he did it, he was taken away for a psychiatric evaluation. I think that he was eventually demoted to E-1 and returned to his unit. A few days ago, however, he threatened to kill several